by us on the basis of humanism and taking into account the interests of the people concerned.

I share your desire to channel a relationship between our countries to a more constructive course. And the brakes are being put on this process in no way due to the existence of the cases of such sort—though I do not tend to belittle their importance from the point of view of the lives of individual persons—but because of the attempts to blow them out of proportion in the general balance of Soviet-American relations. The key issues in this area are awaiting their resolution.

I would like to note in passing: as it can be seen, the continuing attempts by the American side to tie up trade and economic relations with questions of a different nature will bring no benefit. It is high time to take a realistic look at this whole issue from the position of today, rather than yesterday.

It would seem that much will now depend on how accurately we are going to follow jointly the real priorities in our relations, if we wish to bring about their tangible normalization already in the near future. I think, the chances are not bad here.

Sincerely,
M. Gorbachev
January 11, 1986

Four days later Gorbachev sent me still another letter. Several hours before I received it, he made it public in Moscow. (Three weeks earlier, he'd written me that he valued the *private* nature of our confidential correspondence.)

This latest letter was clearly meant for propaganda.

He said the Soviet Union wanted to eliminate all INF weapons from Europe, in effect accepting my 1982 zero-zero proposal for intermediate-range missiles in Europe